

Tempo has a measurable cost

Chess Math

THE IDEA

A tempo is one move's worth of time. You can estimate wasted development by counting repeated moves that do not create compensation. The count is useful only when the opponent can exploit the extra time.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If White moves a knight out, back, and out again while Black develops three different pieces, White has spent two extra turns reaching the same knight placement. Black may use that lead to open the center before White castles.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

When might repeating a piece move be justified?

ANSWER AND REASONING

When it wins material, answers a threat, improves a necessary square, or creates a stronger threat than development would. Lost time is a cost, not an automatic verdict.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Compare the benefit of a repeated move with what one tempo buys the opponent.